



Jayesh Ranjan, Special Chief Secretary for Youth Advancement, Tourism and Culture, Sports, Government of Telangana, J Meghanatha Reddy, Member Secretary, Sports Development Authority, Government of Tamil Nadu, and Raveendran Sankaran, Director General cum CEO, Bihar State Sports Authority during the Sportstar Focus Bihar Conclave. R. V. MOORTHY

Sports administrators outline grassroots policies

Team Sportstar

In a panel discussion titled, 'Many States, One Dream: Fuelling India's Olympic Ambition' at the *Sportstar Focus Bihar Conclave*, administrators from Telangana, Tamil Nadu and Bihar outlined the shift towards grassroots sports and fundamental infrastructure building undertaken by their respective State governments.

Jayesh Ranjan, Special Chief Secretary for Youth Advancement, Tourism and Culture, Sports, Government of Telangana, endorsed a PPP model where different stakeholders play to their strengths in fostering sporting development.

"One of the biggest complaints we hear, and a very valid criticism, is that

the Government pokes its nose far too much in sports administration. It should be left to people with expertise. That said, we should be clear about our responsibilities.

"Infrastructure and grassroots development have to be our duty. Access to government land and funds is our space; grassroots talent development should be our mandate. But managing a sports facility and conducting a scientific coaching programme, etc., have to be done through partners," he said, explaining Telangana's tie-ups with organisations like FIFA and Juventus.

Meanwhile, J. Meghanatha Reddy, Member Secretary, Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu (SDAT), highlighted the impact of the Chief Minister's Trophy, which

has provided a 'sustainable, reliable and continuous platform' for athletes.

"Thirteen lakh sportspersons across the State participated in district-level competitions, of which 13,000 were from the school level, and 12,000 were from colleges. In just these two categories, we have expanded the scope to 24 Olympic and non-Olympic disciplines," he explained.

Raveendran Sankaran, Director General cum CEO, Bihar State Sports Authority, elaborated on the State's three-stage sports scholarship policy.

"The first stage is Prerna, the second one is Saksham, and the third one is Udaan. Under these three categories, 800 athletes are under the scholarship policy. Prerna works at the grassroots level; Saksham is for national-level athletes, and Udaan for the international level. Those under Udaan are given up to Rs. 20 lakh per annum as sports scholarship for training and equipment. Under Saksham, it is Rs. 5 lakh, and at the grassroots level, it is Rs. 3 lakh."